2015 with $15 billion in prepayments when sanctions made a debt rollover impossible, following a decadelong pattern of loans and prepayments (including $70 billion in 2013) to finance Rosneft's acquisitions and growth. In June 2016, CNPC sought a seat on the Rosneft board—an unprecedented act—amid consideration that the Kremlin planned to sell equity stakes to Chinese and Indian companies to raise funds for the state.[172] Russia also edged out Saudi Arabia as the top crude exporter to China by agreeing to accept RMB for payment despite the potential costs. Both China and Russia are also trying to attract interest in their own fledgling oil futures markets in national currencies, a venture that Russia has attempted for over a decade without success.

After prolonged debate, the Russian leadership came to accept that China will be the dominant investor in Eurasia, leading Putin and Xi to agree in May 2015 on coordinating the development of China's OBOR initiative with Russia's plans for the EEU.[173] However Moscow spins this process, Russia remains in a weak bargaining position, meaning that relative gains from this partnership will more likely accrue to China, while enriching select firms and associates close to the Kremlin.

Still, the RMB locomotive has left the station, and Russia is on board with multiple projects, from RMB-ruble exchange trading and issuing "dim sum" bonds to expanding the scope of settlement in national currencies. But like its other BRICS partners, Russia does not benefit from rejecting U.S. dominance, only to fall into China's embrace as the supplicant partner.

Blurring the Offense-Defense Mix in Financial Statecraft

Whether vis-à-vis the West or China, Russian policies to achieve autonomy are sometimes contradictory and bleed into the pursuit of influence. Far-reaching objectives must be scaled back when the gap between Russia's resources and its ambitions grows too wide. There is ample evidence that Putin is willing to gamble to achieve his goals, but usually with an eye to the risks and potential consequences. On a host of issues, the Kremlin allows itself to get pulled back when it starts to veer too far into potentially extreme and costly positions.[174] In financial statecraft, before Putin embarked on the campaign to take over Crimea, he reportedly asked three top officials in February 2014 if Russia could afford the economic blowback. The reply was that Russia's foreign currency reserves were